

Hero Rat Gets a Giant Statue!

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When you think of rats, "hero" is probably not the first word that comes to mind. But Magawa was no ordinary **rodent**. This African giant pouched rat helped save hundreds of lives in Cambodia by sniffing out hidden **landmines** (explosives buried in the ground). On April 3, 2026, Magawa got a seven-foot (2.1 m) stone statue in the city of Siem Reap. That's taller than a tall adult! The statue was **unveiled** on the International Day for Mine Awareness. Magawa was part of a group called HeroRATS, trained by a **nonprofit** called APOPO. These rats have an amazing sense of smell. They can sniff out chemicals in explosives. And they are light enough to walk over **landmines** without setting them off. A single rat can search a tennis-court-sized area in just 20 minutes. A human with a **metal detector** would take four days! Magawa worked for five years in Cambodia. He cleared nearly 1.5 million square feet of land and found more than 100 **landmines**. In 2020, he got a **miniature** gold medal for bravery. He retired in 2021 and passed away peacefully in 2022. Thanks to HeroRATS, over 120,000 **landmines** have been removed. Now those areas can be used for farming, homes, and schools. Magawa may be small, but he's a huge hero.

Word Treasure

landmines -- Explosives hidden in the ground that can hurt people who step on them.

rodent -- A group of mammals with strong front teeth, like rats, mice, and squirrels.

nonprofit -- An organization that does not aim to make money but tries to help people or solve problems.

miniature -- Something made in a very small size, like a tiny version of a real thing.

metal detector -- A device that finds metal objects underground by making a beeping sound.

unveiled -- Showed something for the first time, often by pulling off a cloth covering it.

Background you need

Cambodia (a country in Southeast Asia) had a long war that left millions of landmines buried in fields and forests.

Even today, people in Cambodia can accidentally step on these explosives, so trained animals like Magawa help make land safe for farming and homes.

Siem Reap (a city in Cambodia famous for the Angkor Wat temple) now has a statue of Magawa to honor his brave work.

Break it down

WHO: Magawa, an African giant pouched rat trained to find landmines.

WHAT: A seven-foot stone statue was unveiled for him.

WHERE: In Siem Reap, Cambodia, on the International Day for Mine Awareness.

WHY: Because he saved hundreds of lives by finding over 100 landmines and clearing land safely.

Why it matters

Because of animals like Magawa, children in Cambodia can now play and go to school without fear of hidden bombs, and you can learn that helping others doesn't always require being big and strong.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of animal was Magawa?

- ☐ (A) A dog
- ☐ (B) A rat
- ☐ (C) A rabbit
- ☐ (D) A pigeon

2. What did Magawa help find?

- ☐ (A) Buried treasure
- ☐ (B) Lost keys
- ☐ (C) Hidden landmines
- ☐ (D) Ancient fossils

3. Where was Magawa's statue placed?

- ☐ (A) Phnom Penh
- ☐ (B) Siem Reap
- ☐ (C) Angkor Wat
- ☐ (D) Bangkok

4. How long does a rat take to search a tennis-court-sized area?

- ☐ (A) 4 days
- ☐ (B) 1 hour
- ☐ (C) 20 minutes
- ☐ (D) 2 hours

5. What special award did Magawa receive in 2020?

- ☐ (A) A giant medal
- ☐ (B) A miniature gold medal
- ☐ (C) A certificate
- ☐ (D) A money prize

6. About how many landmines have HeroRATs removed?

- ☐ (A) 10,000
- ☐ (B) 120,000
- ☐ (C) 500
- ☐ (D) 1.5 million

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Animal hero:** Magawa proved rats can be brave helpers. People who love animals cheered his recognition and see him as a real hero.
2. **Skeptical:** Some people still think of rats as dirty pests and might find it strange to give them a statue or a medal.
3. **Practical:** Using trained rats is a smart, low-cost way to clear landmines quickly, but some worry whether it is fair to the animals to work in dangerous places.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):